The ultimate result of these initial problems was a military that was dominated by small state-armed villages, towns, and district militias organized by party leaders. This localized control spelled problems for the development of national identity in the Burmese state. The citizens did not have confidence in the government's ability to protect them. Further hampering efforts was the fact that desertion levels were high in the period from 1948 to 1950.

From 1950 to 1953, the tatmadaw laid the foundation for its eventual consolidation of authority within the state. According to Myanmar military expert Mary Callahan, author of *Making Enemies: War and State Building in Burma*, the expanding institutional clout of the military was a result of the decades-long struggles over how power would be constituted, by whom, and in whose name, and across what territory. Furthermore, the external threat from the KMT (Chinese Nationalist Party) helped the military push for additional funding and training. Many within Myanmar started to look to the military and the leaders within Burma. Civilian politicians did not seem to get the job done, especially in dealing with external threats such as the China insurgency. Slowly but surely, law and order returned to the Burmese countryside. The state ultimately became reliant on army field commanders, warlords, and militia leaders to gain access to the population. The citizens also saw the military as the only way to gain access to the state. Thus, the military played a sort of “middleman” role in Myanmar.

Following Ne Win's promotion to commander and chief of the armed forces in 1949, the Burmese military began an extensive expansion and improvement. As the military bureaucracy in Burma gained strength, substantial increases were seen in funding for training, equipment, and support. Furthermore, the Defense Service Institute became heavily involved in the economic sector. This led to the military having enormous control over the import-export business in Burma. The growing clout of the military widened an earlier rift between civilian politicians and army leaders such as Ne Win and Aung Gyi.

The fact that Burma faced so many threats in the postindependence period set the stage for military dominance in political affairs. War fighters became state builders, according to Callahan. The military would be responsible for resource allocation, centralization of the state, and expansion of territory. Confidence was lost in the civilian government as